TrustHarvest

Presentation guide: pitch, live demo and judge Q&A

HackJos 2026 | Sell it before it spoils: a freshness clock, price tips and safe payment for farmers and cooperative agents

How to use this guide

- Read the green boxes aloud. They are your script. Yellow boxes explain why it works and how to deliver it.
- Everyone on the team should read the Q&A sections. Judges often direct a question at whoever looks least ready.
- Practise the demo until the clicks are automatic. Most hackathon demos last 2 to 5 minutes, and 3 minutes is the most common slot (AngelHack).

Read this first: three honesty points

- **Check the rules about pre-built work.** HackJos describes a 48-hour build, from first idea to final pitch. Your prototype already exists. Ask the organizers (info@hackjos.com.ng, +234 806 889 7177) whether work done before the event is allowed, and plan what you will visibly add during the 48 hours (real SMS integration, a hardware sensor, farmer interviews). Keep your commit history, because it shows what happened when.
- **Never claim what you have not done.** Do not say you tested with farmers, that the shelf-life numbers are scientific, or that payments are real. Section 6 lists what is real and what is simulated.
- **Confirm your track.** Your application may say Market Access & Value Chains. The new story fits Track 04 (Post-Harvest Innovation) best. Ask the organizers which track you will be judged under, and mention both if needed.

1. Run of show (3 minutes plus questions)

Part	Time	Speaker	Goal
Hook	0:00-0:20	Speaker 1	Make the problem feel real
Problem and who it hurts	0:20-0:45	Speaker 1	Show you understand farmers
Solution in one sentence, then three features	0:45-1:10	Speaker 1	Be memorable
Live demo	1:10-2:25	Demo driver	Prove it works
Team and impact	2:25-2:45	Speaker 2 and security teammate	Show you can finish and be trusted
What is next and the ask	2:45-3:00	Speaker 1	End strong

Roles: one speaker, one **demo driver** who only clicks, and one person who watches the clock. Assigning a speaker and a demo driver is standard advice for winning hackathon pitches (Salesforce developer blog). Do not volunteer the problems you hit while building; judges will ask if they care.

2. The pitch script

Hook (0:00)

WHAT TO SAY

Picture a farmer in Plateau State on the morning after harvest. The tomatoes look perfect. By the end of the week, they will not be worth selling. FAO reports that more than half of Nigeria's annual tomato yield is lost. That is not bad luck. It is a countdown that nobody can see. We made it visible.

WHY IT WORKS / HOW TO DELIVER IT

Start with a picture, then one sourced fact. Pause after "countdown that nobody can see". Say the FAO number slowly. It is the only statistic in the pitch and you can name its source (FAO Nigeria).

Problem (0:20)

WHAT TO SAY

Produce starts spoiling the moment it is harvested. Farmers do not know how many days they really have, so they either sell in a panic at a low price or hold on too long and lose everything. Supermarkets protect freshness with cold chains and monitoring. Smallholders have none of that. The result: lost harvest, lost income, and food that never reaches a plate.

WHY IT WORKS / HOW TO DELIVER IT

The supermarket comparison comes from your own notes and lands with judges. Keep the focus on the farmer and the harvest, not on buyers.

Solution (0:45)

WHAT TO SAY

TrustHarvest is a freshness clock for farm produce. A farmer taps the crop, the amount and where it is stored, and the clock starts: green, amber or red, with days left. Three things follow. One, smart price tips, so you sell before it spoils at a fair price. Two, surplus routing, so produce that cannot be sold goes to processors and food banks instead of the bin. Three, alerts by SMS, in English, Pidgin or Hausa, for farmers on basic phones. And every sale builds a record of how long produce lasted under each storage method.

WHY IT WORKS / HOW TO DELIVER IT

One sentence first, then three features, and hold up three fingers. The "record of storage methods" line is your most original feature, so say it clearly.

Demo (1:10)

WHAT TO SAY

Handled by the demo driver. See section 3 for the click-by-click script. The speaker narrates in plain words while the driver clicks.

WHY IT WORKS / HOW TO DELIVER IT

Narrate what the judge should notice ("this one is red, it has no days left"), not what the driver is doing. If something breaks, stay calm and say what should have happened.

Team and impact (2:25)

WHAT TO SAY

Our team is designers, a backend engineer and a cybersecurity specialist, and the mix is deliberate. The designers made it usable by someone who has never used an app. The backend engineer built the freshness engine. Our security lead protects the data and the money that flows through it. For impact, we will measure spoilage avoided, days held before sale, and the share of produce sold at a fair price.

WHY IT WORKS / HOW TO DELIVER IT

Each teammate says one sentence. Name the measures you will track so judges see you can prove impact later. Do not claim impact numbers you do not have.

What is next and the ask (2:45)

WHAT TO SAY

Today, the freshness clock, the price tips, the record and the marketplace work. SMS, payments, ID checks and the hardware sensor are simulated, and the shelf-life values are placeholders that we will replace with postharvest research data. Next: a pilot with a farmers cooperative in Plateau State, real SMS and mobile money, and a calibrated sensor for storage rooms. We are asking for a partner cooperative and mentors in postharvest science. TrustHarvest: sell it before it spoils.

WHY IT WORKS / HOW TO DELIVER IT

Saying what is simulated builds trust, and judges commonly ask what is real and what is mocked (AngelHack). End with a specific ask and your closing line, then stop talking.

3. The live demo, click by click

Setup before you go on stage: run **npm start**, delete **data.json** for fresh demo data, open two browser windows (farmer 0803000001 and buyer 0803000003, password pass1234), set the zoom to a phone-sized window, and record a 60-second backup video.

#	Driver does	Speaker says	Time
1	Show the landing hero for a moment.	"This is what a farmer sees first: sell it before it spoils."	5s
2	Farmer window, Fresh tab. Point at the red and amber cards.	"Red means no days left. Amber means under a day. Each card shows a price tip."	10s
3	Log a batch: tap Pepper, tap Cooler, tap +, tap Start the freshness clock.	"No typing. Big icons. A farmer can do this in ten seconds."	15s
4	On the amber tomatoes tap the price tip button.	"The app suggests lowering the price 15 percent, so it sells before it spoils."	8s
5	On the red tomatoes tap Surplus buyers.	"Too late for fresh sale, so it goes to a processor or food bank. This list is sample data for now."	8s
6	Open Sensor demo, tap Hot room 38C, watch the clocks shorten, tap Clear.	"A temperature sensor in a storage room speeds up or slows down the clock. Here we simulate one."	12s
7	Phone tab: tap Reply 1 on the SMS, then use the USSD menu: type 1, Send.	"Farmers on basic phones get this by SMS and reply with a number. No app, no data."	12s
8	Switch the language to Hausa, then back. Tap the Lite button.	"Three languages, read-aloud, and a lite mode that turns off photos on weak networks."	8s
9	Buyer window, Market tab: show the amber chip, buy 2 baskets. Farmer marks delivered. Buyer confirms.	"The buyer pays into escrow and the farmer is paid on confirmed delivery."	20s
10	Record tab.	"Each sale records how long produce lasted by storage method. This history is seeded sample data; it fills as farmers sell."	10s

IF SOMETHING BREAKS

Say: "This is why we built an audit log" or "Here is what should happen", then move to the next step. Switch to the backup video if the server fails. If the Wi-Fi fails, the app shell still loads offline and the Fresh tab queues new batches until the connection returns. Never apologise at length.

Cut list if you are short on time: steps 8 and 9 first, then 6.

4. The target audience answer (rehearse this one)

WHAT TO SAY

Our end beneficiary is the smallholder farmer, the person whose harvest spoils before it sells. But we are honest that most do not have smartphones today, so we do not start there. Our first users are the people who already stand between farmers and markets: cooperative leaders, aggregators and village agents. They have phones, they handle many farmers' produce, and one agent reaches many farmers at once. Farmers get the benefit through SMS alerts and USSD. The app we built serves that agent layer, and agent mode lets one person log produce on behalf of named farmers.

Why this holds up: it names the access gap before the judge does, and it matches advice from agtech practitioners to build around the farmer's reality and to think about existing buying behaviour before building a new distribution model (Bain and Acumen research; TechEconomy). Farmer adoption also depends on trust that is earned slowly, so a

cooperative pilot is the right first step.

5. Questions judges commonly ask, with our answers

Q: Who is your user, and who pays?

A: The user is the farmer, reached through cooperative agents and SMS. Farmers pay nothing. Our revenue would come from a small fee on completed sales and from cooperatives and processors who value fewer losses and better supply data. We would test the fee in a pilot rather than assume it.

Why this works: Judges tend to ask who the user is and who pays (AngelHack).

Q: What is real and what is mocked?

A: Real: the freshness engine, batch logging, price tips, surplus routing logic, the record, agent mode, offline queue, languages, lite mode, the escrow order flow, trust scores, audit log and fraud flags. Simulated: payments and wallet top-up, ID verification, sending SMS (alerts are generated and shown), the telecom side of USSD, sensor readings (the endpoint is real, the readings are simulated), the processor list, and the demo sales history. Shelf-life days and base prices are placeholder assumptions.

Why this works: Honesty here is the single best credibility move.

Q: What would you build next, and what is your plan after the hackathon?

A: First, replace placeholder shelf-life values with postharvest research values and validate them with farmers. Second, pilot with one cooperative in Plateau State. Third, connect real SMS and a licensed payment provider, and calibrate a storage-room sensor. We would measure spoilage avoided and income effect.

Why this works: Judges ask about the plan after the hackathon (Salesforce developer blog).

Q: Is anyone else doing this? How are you different?

A: Marketplaces exist, cold-chain and storage businesses exist, and farm-record apps exist. Our difference is a farmer-first freshness clock that works for people without cold chains, reaches basic phones through SMS, and turns every sale into a record of which storage method worked. [Before you present, name one or two real competitors you have checked, and say what each does and does not do.]

Why this works: Judges commonly ask whether you have seen similar solutions (e27 mentor and judge).

Q: How big is the market?

A: We will not quote a number we cannot source. What we can source: FAO reports more than half of Nigeria's annual tomato yield is lost, which shows how large the loss is for one crop alone. We would size the market bottom-up in the pilot: number of agents, farmers per agent, and batches per month.

Why this works: Judges look for bottom-up thinking over top-down guesses (CSULB judge question guide).

Q: Why should we believe this team can deliver?

A: Our team covers design, backend and security, which is what the product needs. We built a working prototype with real flows, a security model, and offline and low-data support, and we are clear about what remains.

Why this works: Teams are judged on whether they can execute.

Q: Is the data safe? What about privacy?

A: Passwords are hashed, sessions expire, requests are rate limited, input is validated, and every order status change is logged. The sensor endpoint needs a device key. Farmers' records are private to them, and the community view in the Record tab is anonymous.

Why this works: Your cybersecurity teammate should answer this one.

6. Questions tailored to TrustHarvest (the hard ones)

Q: How accurate is your freshness clock?

A: Right now it uses placeholder shelf-life values by crop and storage method, adjusted by sensor temperature when a sensor is present. We say so openly. The next step is to replace them with published postharvest values and calibrate against what farmers observe. The days-held record is designed to improve the estimates from real data.

Q: You said rural farmers are your focus, but they do not have smartphones. So who is this for?

A: See section 4. The beneficiary is the farmer. The first users are agents and cooperatives. Farmers are reached by SMS and USSD, and lite mode and offline logging help where data is weak.

Q: Did you test this with farmers?

A: Not yet, and we will not pretend otherwise. We have a pilot plan with a cooperative, and we would start with interviews and field validation of the shelf-life values.

Why this works: Never claim testing you have not done.

Q: What did you build during these 48 hours, and what did you build before?

A: [Answer truthfully with your timeline. Describe what existed before the event and what you added during it.] If asked about the rules, say you checked with the organizers.

Why this works: Check the rules with the organizers beforehand.

Q: Your tool started as an escrow marketplace. Why change direction?

A: We found that the bigger problem for farmers is the spoilage clock, not only payment risk. Escrow remains because it lets a farmer sell fast to strangers and be paid safely, which is exactly what produce at risk of spoiling needs.

Q: Who pays for the SMS?

A: In the pilot, the cooperative or a sponsor. In production the cost per alert is small compared with the value of a saved batch, but we have not quoted a figure because we have not negotiated one. SMS is a channel cost we would cover through the fee or partner support.

Q: How do you stop a bad actor from gaming the record or fake listings?

A: Verified profiles, rate limits, an audit log, fraud flags for repeated disputes, and escrow that releases only on confirmed delivery. The record is built from confirmed sales, not from self-reported claims.

Q: What if a farmer or agent cannot read well?

A: Icon-first buttons, large text mode, a read-aloud button, and a USSD-style menu. Hausa and Pidgin text still needs review by native speakers, and we plan to do that in the pilot.

Q: Is the Hausa translation correct?

A: We built a first version for the demo and flagged it for native-speaker review. We would not ship it to farmers before that review.

Q: Are you using AI?

A: Our freshness clock is rule-based today. AI could improve spoilage prediction once we have real data, which is why the record matters. We prefer to be honest rather than add AI as a label.

Q: What about food safety and quality disputes?

A: Disputes freeze the funds, and an admin decides. Over time, the record and photo evidence could support quality claims. We have not built photo checks yet.

7. Questions from other hackathons and pitch events, refined for us

I searched for publicly available judge questions and criteria. I did not find a published list of HackJos judges' questions, so these come from other events and judge guides. They are paraphrased, and they are not quotes from HackJos judges.

Source	Question or criterion (paraphrased)	Our refined answer
AngelHack, hackathon demo guide	Who is the user, who pays, what is real versus mocked, and what would you build next?	User: farmer via agent. Pays: small fee on sales plus cooperatives and processors. Real vs mocked: see section 6 and section 5. Next: pilot, real SMS and payments, sensor calibration.
Salesforce developer blog	What is your plan after the hackathon? What challenges did you face?	Plan: pilot with a cooperative. Challenge: making shelf-life estimates honest without research data, so we used placeholders and clearly labelled them.
CSULB judge question guide	Can you explain the problem and solution simply? Have you gone beyond hunches by talking directly to customers? Is your forecast built bottom-up?	Simple line: "A freshness clock so farmers sell before produce spoils." Customer discovery: not yet, pilot interviews are step one. Forecast: bottom-up from agents x farmers x batches, once we have pilot numbers.
e27, mentor and judge perspective	Have you seen other solutions doing this? Are you describing features or how you solve the problem?	Name 1-2 real competitors and the gap. Lead with the problem (spoilage), then show only the features that solve it.
Pitch AgriHack criteria (smallholder agritech)	What is the impact on smallholder farmers? Can it scale? Is there evidence of effect on income? How many farmers are reached?	Impact measures: spoilage avoided, days held before sale, price realised. Scale: one agent reaches many farmers. Evidence: none yet, pilot will produce it. Reach: [number of farmers your first agent serves, once known].
TechEconomy, agri-tech founders	Is it built around the farmer? Is it affordable? Is trust earned?	Icon-first, free for farmers, SMS and USSD, agent-led, cooperative pilot so trust comes from people farmers already know.
Bain and Acumen, smallholder adoption research	Did you consider existing buying behaviour and mobility before building a last-mile distribution model?	Yes, so we use agents and cooperatives who already collect produce rather than building a new network.
University of Nebraska farm tech study	Does it address economic pressure, reduce risk and stay simple? Is there field validation?	Economic: fewer spoiled batches and better price timing. Risk: alerts and escrow. Simple: icons. Field validation: planned in the pilot.
HackerEarth, UofTHacks scoring example	Is it usable? Does it work? What now?	Usable: large icons, 3 languages, lite mode. Works: live demo. What now: pilot and research-based values.
HackJos 2025 and 2026 coverage (ITEdgeNews)	Is this a real, sustainable business? Does it help a priority group?	Revenue: small fee and partner funding. Beneficiaries: smallholder farmers, traders and cooperatives who are Nigeria's agri MSMEs.

HackJos 2026 coverage says organizers hope to identify high-potential startups and create paths to funding, mentorship, incubation and investment. Expect judges to care about business viability as well as the demo.

8. Handling tough moments

- **If you do not know:** "We have not measured that yet. Here is how we would find out." Never invent a number.
- **If a judge attacks your target audience:** stay calm, use section 4, and do not get defensive. Judges attack hidden gaps and respect named ones.
- **If the question is for the engineer:** answer in one sentence, then offer to show it in the demo.
- **If two of you start talking:** the person who owns the topic answers. The other nods.
- **Keep answers under 30 seconds.** The shortest answer that is true and specific wins.
- **Do not say:** "we ran out of time", "it is just a prototype", "AI" without substance, or any statistic you cannot source.

9. Final checklist

- Chargers, adapter, phone with hotspot, and a backup video on your laptop and phone.
- **npm start** an hour early, and delete **data.json** for fresh demo data.
- Two browser windows logged in (farmer and buyer), window sized like a phone.
- Confirm the rules on pre-built work and your track with the organizers.
- Replace the bracketed answers in this guide with your real competitor names and your real build timeline.
- Credit the photographers and check each photo's licence.
- Practise the full 3 minutes out loud at least three times, with a timer.

Closing line: TrustHarvest. Sell it before it spoils.

Sources

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